Civil Society Coalition on Sustainable Development (Oyo State Chapter)

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PRESS RELEASE

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CORONAVIRUS (CoVID-19) PANDEMIC IN OYO STATE

The Oyo State Chapter of the Civil Society Coalition on Sustainable Development (www.cscsdev.org) is an arm of over 2000 Non-Governmental Organisations and networks working on SDGs related issues in Nigeria. We hereby wish to make some remarks in light of the raging public health crisis occasioned by coronavirus outbreak.

It is no more news that the epidemic that originated in Wuhan, China in December 2019 has become a pandemic currently ravaging the globe, with its worst impacts felt in the global north. The pandemic constitutes an assault on the SDGs as it hits at the heart of Goal 3 which aims at ensuring healthy-life and promoting well-being of all at all ages. The interconnectedness of the 17 Goals implies that the pandemic affects all facets of human existence. Therefore, Nigeria is at the risk of failing to realize the 2030 Agenda as CoVID-19 is ravaging in addition to Boko Haram insurgency, banditry, herders-farmers' killings, and kidnapping.

Nigeria has started to report cases, the index being an Italian expatriate who works in Ogun State and returned to the Country through Murtala Mohammed International Airport, Lagos over three weeks ago. Within a short spate of time, the cumulative number of reported cases in Nigeria has risen to 111 with 1 fatality, as of today 30th March 2020. Most of these cases are in Lagos and Abuja, while Osun, Oyo, Ogun, Edo, Rivers, Bauchi and Ekiti have also recorded one or two cases at least.

Regrettably in the Oyo State scenario, a Nigerian returnee from the United States of America is among the cases as well as a young American man, who reportedly spent two weeks in the city before transiting to Ekiti State where he eventually died. It is notable that all these Covid-19 cases have been those with travel histories to the global North. They came back without obvious symptoms and failed to self-isolate.

We seize this opportunity to applaud the proactive steps taken by Oyo State government to curb the pandemic; though there was an initial tardiness. The establishment of the Oyo State Covid-19 Task Force Enforcement Team and a number of sub-committees is commendable. So is the setting up of the Emergency Operational Centres with a Diagnostic Centre in collaboration with National Centre for Disease Control on training and capacity building for Covid-19 fight.

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Though not enough, there has been widespread community sensitization and awareness, the popularization of hand washing, use of hand sanitizers, guidelines for social distancing, guidelines for public transportation. All of these are to maintain proper hygienic standards.

There has also been a prohibition of mass gatherings, closure of schools (private and public), nightclubs, places of worship (churches and mosques) in addition to enforcement of stay-at-home orders for Federal, State and Local Government workers for two weeks with the exception of those providing essential services.

However we believe, as a coalition working on SDGs in Oyo State, much still needs to be done in terms of sensitization and awareness not just for urban dwellers but also the rural dwellers of Oyo State. We therefore implore the government (state and local) with the support of civil society and other stakeholders to deepen and intensify the ongoing community sensitization and awareness on the nature, transmission and prevention methods to help stem the tide of this terrible pandemic (CoVID-19).

It is sad to note that Oyo State and indeed the whole of Nigeria lack robust health infrastructure to cope with the medical treatment of Covid-19 illness. This is because it is economically and emotionally expensive as well as physically draining even for governments in the most advanced countries. Therefore, we need to urgently increase our sensitization campaigns to the communities to ensure preventive measures at individual, family and community levels. We as CSCSD pledge our support in reaching the nooks and crannies of Oyo State with the needed actions for this purpose.

Community education needs to be promoted on the importance of self-isolation and quarantine. We implore Oyo State government to intensify the surveillance and contact-tracing for case-finding and monitoring of individuals who are returnees from CoVID-19 high prevalence countries by continuous sensitizing the communities to report cases through the CoVID-19 dedicated hotlines which the government has already made available. This will assist in curbing community transmission.

It is understood that the immediate and intermediate impact of the economic dislocation due to market closures, stay at home orders and possible lockdowns would be enormous. As most Nigerians live at subsistence level, Oyo Government with the support from the Federal Government should be ready with suitable palliatives to ease the suffering of the Oyo State population.

We suggest that government should shutdown non-essential markets, while operators of nightclubs, cinemas, religious worship centres should abide by the directives from both the state and the federal governments. Governments should provide emergency facilities and equipment including infra-red thermometers, ventilators, and other medicaments to savage the lives of the infected while sanitizers should be made available at very low prices.

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When this storm has mercifully abated, it should now be time to face the daunting task of honestly rebuilding the 3-tiered health system which has become moribund and ineffectual, operating at best for the purpose of workers' salaries and emoluments. It will be time to make painful decisions that will see us put in place effective and efficient primary, secondary and tertiary system that will serve our people with a humane healthcare. This kind of system will help us achieve SDG 3 – promoting healthy life and well-being for all.

Long Live Nigeria!!! Long Live Oyo State!!!

Mr. Kolawole AMUSAT
State Co-ordinator

Mr. Femi Gabriel, OYENIYI
State Secretary

Tola WINJOBI (Ph. D.)
National Co-ordinator

Member organizations signing on to the statement:

1. Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN) Nigeria
2. Child Protection Network (CPN)
3. CAFSO-WRAG for Development
4. Initiative For Integrated Community Welfare In Nigeria (IICWIN)
5. Justice Development and Peace Movement
6. Centre For Disaster Risk And Crisis Reduction (CDRCR)
7. Federation of Muslim Women Association of Nigeria (FOMWAN)
8. National Youth Network
9. Cedars For Human Welfare
10. Maria Ebun Foundation
11. Centre For Peace Building and Disaster Relief
12. Centre For Youth Initiative on Self Education
13. National Youth Council of Nigeria
14. Tax Justice and Governance Platform
15. Centre For Community Health and Poverty Alleviation
16. Association of Community Birth Attendants and Voluntary Health Workers of Nigeria
17. Endonamoo Transformation Global Initiative
18. Airat Ogugbenro Children Protection Initiative
19. World Islamic Peace Foundation
20. Jesus Children Missions Outreach